

MCS-DOS 2.0

A DOS shell
for the Commodore 64.

User's Guide and Reference



Published by MCS Labs

© 2026

Table of contents

Introduction	4
License	4
1. Features and limitations	5
2. Development notes	6
3. Contents of the cartridge	6
4. Running MCS-DOS	7
Startup	7
Boot configuration	7
Safe mode	8
Cartridge storage	8
5. Using the shell	9
The command prompt	9
Running programs	9
Using Commodore BASIC	9
Devices	10
Redirection and piping	10
Theming	10
6. Commands	11
ATTRIB	11
BASIC	12
BEEP	12
CHKDSK	12
CLS	13
COPY	13
DEL	14
DELETE	15
DIR	15
DISKCOPY	16
DISKID	16
DISKINIT	17
ECHO	17
EDIT	18
ERASE	19
FIND	19
FORMAT	19

HELP	20
LABEL	20
MEM	21
MOVE	21
PAUSE	22
PRINT	22
REBOOT	22
REM	23
REN	23
RENAME	23
RUN	24
SET	24
SPLASH	25
SYSINFO	25
TAPECOPY	26
TYPE	27
VER	28
VERSION	28
VOL	28
7. Environment variables	29
The MCS-DOS environment	29
CHARSET	29
COLOR	30
DIRCMD	30
DRIVEIDS	31
PROMPT	31
8. Command output redirection	32
9. Batch scripting	33
Creating and running batch files	33
Batch processing	33
Example	33
AUTOEXEC.BAT	34
10. Changelog	35
11. About the author	37

Introduction

MCS-DOS is a MS-DOS-inspired operating environment designed to work on a Commodore 64, Commodore 64 Ultimate, Commodore 128 in C64 mode, or on emulators. No RAM expansions or CPU upgrades are needed. It provides familiar prompts, commands and syntax to perform disk and file operations. You can run programs just as you would on a stock setup, and the BASIC environment is always just one command away. Rudimentary batch scripting is also supported.

MCS-DOS was created for fun and novelty, and the author makes no claims as to its real-life usefulness. The software is distributed free of charge and licensed under the MIT license.

MS-DOS is property of Microsoft Corporation. No copyright infringement is intended.

Source code and releases are available on GitHub: <https://github.com/mvanwijk83/mcs-dos>. Code contributions, bug reports, feature requests and discussions are welcome.

License

Copyright (C) 2026 MCS Labs

Permission is hereby granted, free of charge, to any person obtaining a copy of this software and associated documentation files (the "Software"), to deal in the Software without restriction, including without limitation the rights to use, copy, modify, merge, publish, distribute, sublicense, and/or sell copies of the Software, and to permit persons to whom the Software is furnished to do so, subject to the following conditions:

The above copyright notice and this permission notice shall be included in all copies or substantial portions of the Software.

THE SOFTWARE IS PROVIDED "AS IS", WITHOUT WARRANTY OF ANY KIND, EXPRESS OR IMPLIED, INCLUDING BUT NOT LIMITED TO THE WARRANTIES OF MERCHANTABILITY, FITNESS FOR A PARTICULAR PURPOSE AND NONINFRINGEMENT. IN NO EVENT SHALL THE AUTHORS OR COPYRIGHT HOLDERS BE LIABLE FOR ANY CLAIM, DAMAGES OR OTHER LIABILITY, WHETHER IN AN ACTION OF CONTRACT, TORT OR OTHERWISE, ARISING FROM, OUT OF OR IN CONNECTION WITH THE SOFTWARE OR THE USE OR OTHER DEALINGS IN THE SOFTWARE.

1.Features and limitations

MCS-DOS is not a straight MS-DOS clone or emulator; you cannot use it to read PC disks and files, let alone execute programs. It also does not attempt to implement the full DOS feature set (regardless of any version). MCS-DOS takes a workable subset of MS-DOS features and adds a few of its own, allowing you to use your Commodore 64 in a similar, command-line driven manner in a way that makes sense for the system and works with its limitations and the architectural differences it has with the IBM PC platform.

It is also a command shell rather than a full operating system, as it does not control the Commodore 64 at a low level; it still relies on the Commodore 64 KERNAL for system services. Nevertheless, it offers a genuine DOS look & feel and can certainly be utilized as a full-fledged alternative operating environment, supporting all common file and disk operations. If you enjoy DOS-style command line interfaces, you will be right at home here.

The main features are:

- Many familiar DOS commands and utilities are implemented.
- Configuration via `AUTOEXEC.BAT` and `CONFIG.SYS`.
- Some batch file support.
- Supports multiple attached drives and multiple models (1541, 1541-II, 1570, 1571, 1581).
- Drives can be optionally displayed and addressed with DOS-style drive letters.
- Simple built-in text editor.
- Ability to run native programs from the MCS-DOS environment and use BASIC, with return to shell (under some conditions).
- Quality-of-life features such as command history and filename auto-completion.
- Environment variables.
- Output redirection to files.
- File printing.
- Command help easily accessible from the shell (via `/?` and the `HELP` command).
- Customizable shell including command prompts, colors and custom character sets.

Some notable limitations and omissions include:

- No subdirectory support. This is a limitation of the standard CBM-DOS file system.
- No fastload or other disk access optimization routines are implemented. Standard disk transfer speeds apply, unless ROM replacements such as JiffyDOS or DolphinDOS are used.
- No support for hard disks, SD2IEC, Ultimate storage, etc. Only standard CBM-formatted disks are supported, so no GEOS disks etc. either.
- Native programs launched from the shell cannot always return to the MCS-DOS shell. This is not only because many don't "exit" as such, but also because MCS-DOS relies on a RAM-resident return hook that may get overwritten by the software.
- Batch files do not support variables, conditionals, labels, or parameters.
- No piping (`|` syntax) or input redirection (`<`).
- Due to the shell's mixed-case mode, half of PETSCII's graphics characters do not display correctly, and cannot be typed.

Future versions may address these and other shortcomings where possible.

2. Development notes

MCS-DOS started as a simple throwaway project for personal entertainment, motivated by a geeky impulse to see a believable DOS-style environment running on the C64, supporting only a few basic commands. Once things started to look genuinely usable, it became a serious project, and a continuing effort to keep improving and polishing it.

The software was written in C and compiled with Oscar64 on Windows 11. It was tested on a C64 Ultimate and in the VICE emulator. Automated unit and regression testing is implemented with Node.js.

AI disclosure: OpenAI's Codex has been extensively used to assist with implementation, review, and automated unit/regression testing and building. MCS-DOS has however been designed in detail with human creativity and intellect, and generated code has been manually reviewed and modified where necessary. Additionally, extensive human testing was done on both hardware and VICE.

3. Contents of the cartridge

MCS-DOS 2.0 is distributed as an EasyFlash cartridge image. The following files are bundled with the software:

<code>AUTOEXEC.SAMPLE</code>	Example of an <code>AUTOEXEC.BAT</code> file, demonstrating some basic customization options. Rename the file to enable.
<code>CGA.CPI</code>	A custom character set reproducing the 8x8 IBM CGA font. The shell can be configured to use this font instead of the C64 system font by setting the character set in <code>AUTOEXEC.BAT</code> . See chapter 7 for more information.
<code>CHANGELOG.TXT</code>	A version-by-version list of changes to MCS-DOS.
<code>CONFIG.SAMPLE</code>	Example of a <code>CONFIG.SYS</code> file, demonstrating additional boot configurations settings. Rename the file to enable.
<code>LICENSE.TXT</code>	The MIT license as it applies to MCS-DOS.
<code>MANUAL.TXT</code>	An abridged plain text version of this manual.

The main shell program and associated data are internal to the cartridge, and are not visible to the file system. (In the previous disk-based versions 1.0 and 1.01, the shell program and the command help library were represented by discrete files named `MCS-DOS.EXE` and `COMMANDS.HLP`, respectively.)

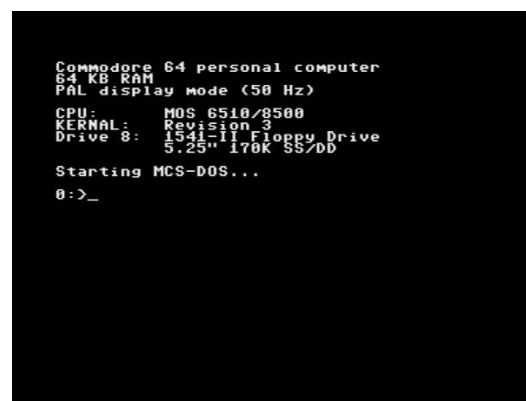
4. Running MCS-DOS

Startup

If you have a physical EasyFlash cartridge, start MCS-DOS from the menu. The .CRT image must have been flashed onto the cartridge first.

In VICE, use File -> Attach cartridge image. On an Ultimate, enter the file browser and run the .CRT.

Upon booting the software, you are presented by a logo splash screen and some basic information about your system that MCS-DOS has detected. Ultimate boards are recognized (but needs Command Interface enabled – if detection still fails, reenable it from the Ultimate menu), as well as JiffyDOS and DolphinDOS replacement KERNALs.



MCS-DOS boot-up sequence: the logo splash screen, system test, and entry to the command shell.

Boot configuration

If an AUTOEXEC.BAT is present, it will execute before you arrive at the shell prompt. You can use it to apply custom settings to the environment, render (echo) custom output, or to issue any other commands you want ran at startup. It is not present by default; create it or rename the sample file. See chapter 7 for more information on how to configure and customize the shell via environment variables, and chapter 8 for information about batch files.

By default, MCS-DOS looks for AUTOEXEC.BAT in the writable area of the cartridge image. This behaviour can be changed in CONFIG.SYS, which is processed before AUTOEXEC.BAT. The following directives are available:

- | | |
|----------------------------|--|
| BOOTDRV=drive[,...] | Specify one or more drives where MCS-DOS should seek AUTOEXEC.BAT, in that order. For example, BOOTDRV=8,0 will look for AUTOEXEC.BAT on the first disk drive (device 8) first, and then on the cartridge (device 0) if it wasn't found. If BOOTDRV is omitted, device 0 is assumed. |
| LDAUTOEX=0 1 | Whether AUTOEXEC.BAT should be executed at all. LDAUTOEX=0 will disable it; BOOTDRV would then not take effect either. The default value when omitted is 1 (i.e. load and run AUTOEXEC.BAT). |

The CONFIG.SYS directives are case-insensitive, and whitespace is ignored.

Safe mode

You can press **RESTORE** on the boot screen to enter a "safe mode"; it will skip processing of the startup files, applying default settings instead. This can be useful to correct misconfigurations that have rendered your shell unusable.

Cartridge storage

64,000 bytes of user-writable storage is available on the cartridge image. It is the default location for your startup configuration files and where the bundled documentation resides. However, nothing stops you from storing anything else you may want to keep there. Indeed, if your boot script references resources not bundled with MCS-DOS, you might want to copy them there instead of relying on an external disk.

A custom, append-only journaling file system is implemented to allow for fast file operations while reducing physical flash writes. It however requires occasional compaction to reclaim space from stale metadata records and deleted content. This happens automatically, which is noticeable as a slowdown during writes when it occurs. Compaction can also be forced via the `CHKDSK /C` command.

Changes to the writable area of the cartridge image persist automatically on a real EasyFlash cartridge. In VICE, you may have to enable writeback settings. On an Ultimate, you need to press **F1** in the Ultimate menu, go to **Power & Reset**, and select **Save Cartridge**. This updated image must be loaded next time you use MCS-DOS.

5. Using the shell

The command prompt

See chapter 6 for a list of supported commands. The command interpreter is case-insensitive, and treats spaces before switches as optional. For example, `DIR/W` and `DIR /W` both work. The maximum full length of a command, including parameters, is 64 characters.

You can use `CRSR LEFT/RIGHT` to move within the command text, while typing inserts. The last ten commands are retained in a history buffer; use `CRSR UP/DOWN` to cycle through them.

When specifying file names as command parameters, double-quote them if they contain spaces or a slash, e.g.:

```
COPY "MY DATA" B:
```

File name autocompletion is implemented and can be invoked with the Commodore key. If there are no preceding characters, it will start from the first alphabetical entry on the active disk. Existing input will be completed if there are exact matches; e.g. typing `MAN` followed by pressing the Commodore key will bring up `MANUAL.TXT` if that's the first match in the current directory. There may be a small initial delay as MCS-DOS builds the directory cache. Rely on this feature especially if file names contain PETSCII graphics characters that do not display correctly in the shell's mixed-case mode; the autocomplete internally preserves the byte-correct original filename.

The appearance of the command prompt can be configured with `SET PROMPT` in `AUTOEXEC.BAT` to be applied at startup. See chapter 7 for more details.

`RUN/STOP` aborts operations where possible (think of it as the `Ctrl+C` equivalent). When typing on the prompt, it will clear the current input.

Running programs

Native C64 programs or batch files can be started from the shell using the `RUN` command. Batch files run fully within the shell and return control after completion.

Native program return is not guaranteed. Not only do many programs not actually exit; for a successful return to the MCS-DOS shell, they must use the standard BASIC return at `$0302-$0303`, and not wholly or partially overwrite the `$C000-$C1FF` area, which contains the MCS-DOS shell re-entry hook. Otherwise, reset the machine (or, when using a physical EasyFlash, use the cartridge reset button) to start a new MCS-DOS session.

When the shell transfers control to an external program, the current shell state (including settings, history, and internal caches) is saved to the cartridge, and restored if the MCS-DOS return hook is successfully reached. If restoration fails for some reason, default shell settings will be applied.

Using Commodore BASIC

The BASIC command can be used to enter the C64 BASIC environment. MCS-DOS installs a return wedge that allows you to return to the shell by typing `SHELL` at the BASIC prompt; however, some programs may partially or wholly overwrite the memory area (`$C000-$C1FF`) in which it is resident, in which case this will fail. As with native program execution, shell state is saved before entering BASIC, and restored upon return.

Devices

MCS-DOS supports standard C64 device numbers as well as DOS-style letter aliases: drive 8 is A, drive 9 is B, etc., which can be used interchangeably. The display convention used by system commands is determined by the `DRIVEIDS` environment variable (see chapter 7). Typing a drive number or letter followed by a colon (e.g. `8:`, `A:`) will select that drive as the current one. The cartridge is identified as drive 0 regardless of C64 or DOS display mode.

Similarly, for print commands both drive numbers 4 and 5 can be specified, or DOS aliases `LPT1` and `LPT2`.

Supported floppy drive models are 1541, 1541-II, 1570, 1571 and 1581.

Some Datasette (tape) support is present in the form of the `TAPECOPY` command which can be used to transfer files from tape to disk or cartridge. Program (PRG) or sequential data (SEQ) files of up to 44 kb can be transferred, assuming no custom loader is used on the source tape. If a non-standard tape header is identified, `TAPECOPY` will terminate.

Redirection and piping

Command output redirection to file is supported. See chapter 9 for more extensive information. Input redirection, printer redirection and piping (`|` syntax) are not supported.

Theming

The appearance of the shell (colors, character set, prompt format, drive identifiers) can be customized via environment variables. See chapter 7 for more information.

6. Commands

The MCS-DOS command set is largely a subset of MS-DOS, but a few unique commands and command options are available as well to support Commodore 64-specific features, or simply because they appear useful.

A list of supported commands can be viewed from within the shell by typing `HELP`. Help on a specific command can be viewed by typing `HELP command`, or by using the `/?` switch with that particular command. For example, to view help on `COPY`, the following commands are equivalent:

```
HELP COPY
COPY /?
```

Most file-based operations work with wildcards `*` and `?` as well.

In most cases, the output of commands will paginate if they exceed the vertical screen space.

For readability, command names are displayed in upper case in this chapter. Note however that the actual command shell is case-insensitive, and commands will also work when typed in lower or even mixed case.

ATTRIB

Displays or changes file attributes.

Syntax:

```
ATTRIB [+L | -L] [[drive:]filename]
```

Description:

The CBM-DOS file system implements a “file lock” bit which prevents a file from being deleted or overwritten. Older MCS-DOS versions (1.0 and 1.01) used the letter `R` instead of `L` to mirror the MS-DOS read-only attribute. This has been changed to more accurately reflect CBM-DOS behavior and semantics. No backwards compatibility has been implemented in MCS-DOS 2.0.

If `ATTRIB` is run without attribute modifiers or a filename, a list of all files within the current directory is displayed with their respective attributes.

Examples:

Set and remove a lock to a file:

```
ATTRIB +L REPORT.TXT
ATTRIB -L REPORT.TXT
```

View attributes of an individual file or a group of files (using wildcards):

```
ATTRIB REPORT.TXT
ATTRIB *.TXT
```

BASIC

Starts the Commodore 64 BASIC environment.

Syntax:

BASIC

Description:

Using the BASIC command will suspend the MCS-DOS shell and transfer control to the Commodore 64 BASIC environment. MCS-DOS reserves the RAM between addresses \$C000-\$C1FF (49152-49663) to install a return “wedge”, and to handle hand-off and return logic. The wedge is a custom SHELL command that you can type in BASIC to return to the MCS-DOS shell. This functionality remains available as long as no program executed within the BASIC environment overwrites that area.

The reserved area lives “above” the reserved BASIC RAM; the full 38911 bytes workspace therefore remains available for BASIC programs.

Prior to entering BASIC, the current shell state (including configuration, history, and internal caches) is saved to the cartridge, and restored if the MCS-DOS return hook is successfully reached. If restoration fails for some reason, default shell settings will be applied.

BEEP

Plays a SID beep.

Syntax:

BEEP [duration]

Duration is in milliseconds. The default value is 200 milliseconds.

Example:

Play a beep with a duration of half a second:

BEEP 500

CHKDSK

Checks a disk and returns a status report.

Syntax:

CHKDSK [drive:] [/V] [/C]

Description:

The CHKDSK command shows the status of the current or specified disk. It also provides a validation feature and can perform an on-demand compaction of the cartridge’s user-writable storage.

When run without switches, CHKDSK displays the total amount of disk space, the space allocated for the files currently on the disk, and the amount of free space. These are measured in bytes. Additionally, the disk size and space remaining are displayed in blocks, where one block is 256 bytes (of which 254 bytes can contain data; the remaining 2 bytes are metadata). This is however not displayed when querying the cartridge storage, as disk blocks are not a meaningful entity here. Finally, the drive model and drive identifiers (device number and DOS letter) are reported.

The following switches are available:

- /V** Executes the CBM-DOS **VALIDATE** command on a floppy disk. It reconciles the block availability map (BAM) with the actual directory contents, freeing any blocks no longer in use by files and deleting all unclosed files. This functionality is not available on drive 0 (the MCS-DOS cartridge).
- /C** “Compacts” the user-writable cartridge storage area if required. This removes stale metadata records and removes file data marked as deleted. Compaction normally occurs automatically when the cartridge file system is determined to be “full” during a write. It is not applicable to disk drives.

Examples:

Output a status report of the current disk, or a specific one:

```
CHKDSK
CHKDSK 8:
CHKDSK B:
```

The output can also be redirected to a file:

```
CHKDSK > STATUS.TXT
```

Validate the current or a specific disk:

```
CHKDSK /V
CHKDSK 8: /V
```

Compact the cartridge file system:

```
CHKDSK /C
```

CLS

Clears the screen.

Syntax:

```
CLS
```

Description:

Running CLS will clear the screen of all currently visible output, leaving a blank screen with only the prompt and cursor. Aside from letting you work in the shell with a “clean slate”, it may also be useful in batch scripts.

COPY

Copies a file to another location, or combines files on the same disk.

Syntax:

```
COPY source destination [/P]
COPY source1+source2[+...] destination
```

Description:

Use COPY with a source and destination to transfer a file to another drive, or to create a duplicate under another name. Both can include a drive specifier. COPY can also be used to concatenate multiple

different files into one single destination file, but beware that due to CBM-DOS limitations, the combined source and destination string cannot exceed 40 characters.

If an existing file is overwritten, you will be prompted for confirmation.

The following switches are available:

/P Suppresses the confirmation prompt to overwrite an existing file.

Examples:

Copy a file from the one drive to another drive (device 9):

```
COPY MYDATA 9:  
COPY A:DIARY.TXT B:
```

Create a copy of a file under another name:

```
COPY REPORT.TXT REPORT2.TXT
```

Copy all files matching the specified wild cards to another drive:

```
COPY *.TXT B:  
COPY REPORT* 9:
```

Concatenate several files into one single combined file:

```
COPY 01+02+03+04 ALL.DAT  
COPY *.TXT+REPORT* COMBINED.TXT
```

DEL

Deletes one or more files.

Syntax:

```
DEL [drive:]filename [/P]  
DELETE [drive:]filename [/P]  
ERASE [drive:]filename [/P]
```

Description:

A single file or a group of files matching a wildcard can be deleted (“scratched” in traditional C64 terminology) from the current or specified drive. By default, MCS-DOS prompts for confirmation to proceed with deleting a file. When multiple files are deleted through the use of a wildcard, confirmation is asked for each matching file. This behavior can be overridden with the /P switch.

The following switches are available:

/P Suppresses the confirmation prompt to delete a file.

Examples:

Delete a single file on the current drive:

```
DEL MAIN.ASM
```

Delete a single file on a different drive:

```
DEL A:HISCORES
```

Delete a group of files matching a wildcard:

```
DEL *.TXT  
DEL VACATION*
```

Delete a group of files matching a wildcard, but suppress the confirmation prompt:

```
DEL *.TXT /P
```

DELETE

Alias of DEL.

DIR

Displays a list of files on a disk.

Syntax:

```
DIR [drive:][pattern] [/B /L /Osortorder /Ttype /W]
```

Description:

The DIR command when typed without any parameters will produce a list of all files on the current drive. A drive and/or a pattern (filename or a wildcard expression) will output a corresponding listing.

Aside from file statistics including file name, type and size, DIR will also show the label and the ID of the specified or current drive, as well as the number of files and their combined size, and the amount of space free on the drive. Amounts are given in both bytes and drive blocks (units of 256 bytes; abbreviated bl in the command output).

Contrary to classic DOS, dates and times are not displayed because they are not saved by the CBM-DOS file system; a C64 does not normally contain a battery-backed real-time clock unless third-party expansion hardware is installed.

The file type column matches the native CBM-DOS types:

DEL	Normally represents an entry that has been deleted from the disk, but can also be explicitly created and visible in a directory. Often used for purposes such as creating separators between entries, or for directory art.
PRG	A file containing executable code. Not all PRG files are necessarily actual runnable programs, as they may also represent “fragments” of code that are dynamically loaded by another program, or even data.
REL	A “relative” file that contains a set of structured records that are indexed on the file system, permitting records to be addressed directly without seeking from the start. In essence, a very simple database.
SEQ	A “sequential” file; i.e., an unstructured data file that is read from start to end. They are often used to store text or other data.
USR	A “user” file. Treated identically to a sequential file, but by convention intended to denote data formatted for special purposes.

The following switches are available:

/B	Uses bare format: lists file names only with no further file and directory statistics.
/L	Displays file names in lower case.

/O Lists files in sorted order. A sort option can be appended (default is N):
N Alphabetically by name.
T Alphabetically by type.
S By size, smallest first.
A minus sign (-) can be prepended to the sort option to reverse the order. F can be added to always show the first-written file on top.

/T Lists files of a given type. Append D=DEL, P=PRG, S=SEQ, U=USR, R=REL.

/W Displays file names in wide format (two columns, no file statistics).

Examples:

Show the full directory of the current drive, or that of a different one:

```
DIR
DIR 8:
```

Show only file names, in lower case:

```
DIR /B /L
```

Show files ordered by size (largest first), and preserve the first entry:

```
DIR /O-SF
```

Output can be redirected to a file:

```
DIR A:*.TXT > TEXTFILES
```

DISKCOPY

Copies the contents of one disk to another.

Syntax:

```
DISKCOPY source: destination:
```

Description:

The source and destination drives must be of the same model; e.g. it is possible to duplicate a disk between two 1541 drives, or two 1571s, but from a 1541 to a 1571 or vice versa is currently not supported. Both drives must be switched on. Due to memory limitations, it is also not possible to duplicate a disk using only a single drive with a disk swap in between.

Example:

Copy the contents of drive A (8) to B (9):

```
DISKCOPY A: B:
```

DISKID

Changes the drive's two-character ID.

Syntax:

```
DISKID [drive:] [id]
```

Description:

Standard Commodore disks have a two-character alphanumeric ID. The disk ID does not have a set purpose, but it may be used as e.g. a serial number, or by multi-disk software to identify whether the expected disk is inserted.

If no drive is specified, the current drive is assumed. If the ID is omitted, DISKID will prompt for it. DISKID does not work on the MCS-DOS cartridge.

Examples:

Change the ID of the current disk but have MCS-DOS prompt for the name:

```
DISKID
```

Change the ID of a disk in drive A (8) to "01":

```
DISKID A: 01
```

DISKINIT

Resets disk drive state and forces a re-read of the directory.

Syntax:

```
DISKINIT [drive:]
```

Description:

This command executes the CBM-DOS INITIALIZE command. It forces the disk drive to re-read the disk's block allocation map (BAM) into its internal memory. This may sometimes be needed when disks with the same ID (see DISKID) are swapped, leaving the disk drive's cache in an inconsistent state.

If the drive parameter is omitted, the current drive is assumed.

ECHO

Displays messages, or turns command-echoing on or off.

Syntax:

```
ECHO [ON | OFF]  
ECHO [message]  
ECHO.
```

Description:

When a batch file is executing, the default DOS behavior is to display (echo) the command that is being executed. This can be turned off by using the OFF option with the ECHO command. Similarly, this behavior can be re-enabled with ECHO ON. If neither ON or OFF are specified, the current setting is displayed.

To prevent an ECHO OFF command in a batch file from being echoed itself, you can prepend the command with an at-symbol (@).

ECHO can also be used to display a line of text on the screen, which can be useful in batch scripts. The message cannot contain line-breaks; to display multiple successive lines of text, put several ECHO commands after each other. Using ECHO. (a dot with no separating space) will force a blank line.

It is possible to omit the line terminator by putting a semi-colon (;) at the end of a message. This will cause the following output to continue on the same line. A double semi-colon (;;) should be used to display the character literal instead.

Example:

A batch file that demonstrates disabling command echoing, displaying messages, and inserting blank lines:

```
@ECHO OFF
ECHO Put the destination disk in drive B.
PAUSE
FORMAT B:
ECHO.
ECHO Put the source disk in drive A.
PAUSE
DISKCOPY A: B:
ECHO Done.
```

EDIT

Edits one screen of text.

Syntax:

```
EDIT [filename]
```

Description:

MCS-DOS has a simple file editor that provides a 40 columns by 24 rows surface of editable text. It is intended for basic editing of small files; it does not handle longer files at this stage. A file name can be specified on the command line to open an existing file, or to create a new file under that name. If no file name was specified, you will be asked for one when saving the file.

You can freely use the cursor keys to navigate around the screen. Typing overwrites. The following edit keys are available:

RETURN	Moves to the next row.
INST/DEL	Deletes the previous character.
SHIFT+INST/DEL	Inserts a space after the current position.
CTRL+INST/DEL	Inserts a blank line before the current one.
CLR/HOME	Moves the cursor to the top left corner.

The bottom row is occupied by a status bar. It shows the current line and column, separated by a colon (e.g. 08:02 when the cursor is on the second column of the eighth row), and the file name if applicable.

When you are done editing, press RUN/STOP. EDIT will then ask if you want to save the file, and prompts for a filename if not previously specified.

The saved file will contain carriage return line endings, and trailing row spaces and unused bottom rows are trimmed.

ERASE

Alias of DEL.

FIND

Searches for a text string in a file.

Syntax:

```
FIND [/V] [/C] [/N] [/I] "string" [[drive:]filename]
```

Description:

The FIND command looks for the specified string in a single file. The string must be enclosed in double quotes. It then displays any lines it has found that contain the string (or don't, if /V is used). The search is case-sensitive by default.

The following switches are available:

/V	Displays all lines <i>not</i> containing the specified string.
/C	Displays only the count of lines containing the string.
/N	Displays line numbers with the displayed lines. Displayed lines will be truncated where necessary.
/I	Performs a case-insensitive search.

Examples:

Finds the string "DOS" in the file MANUAL.TXT:

```
FIND "DOS" MANUAL.TXT
```

Displays the number of lines containing a comma in the file NOTES.TXT:

```
FIND "," /C NOTES.TXT
```

Displays all lines *not* containing the string "IN" (case-insensitive) in the file LOREM IPSUM, and shows the line numbers:

```
FIND "IN" /V /N /I "LOREM IPSUM"
```

FORMAT

Formats a disk.

Syntax:

```
FORMAT drive:
```

Description:

The FORMAT command executes the CBM-DOS disk command NEW, which prepares a disk for use with a Commodore 64 disk drive. Any data already contained on it will be irrevocably deleted. You must specify the drive that contains the disk to format. You will be prompted to insert a disk if none is present in the drive yet. FORMAT infers the required sector and track format from the drive model.

When you format a disk, you will also be asked to provide a label (disk name) and two-character disk ID.

HELP

Displays help on MCS-DOS commands.

Syntax:

HELP [command]

Description:

HELP with no command parameter will display a list of MCS-DOS commands. Invoking HELP with a command name is equivalent to using the `/?` switch on that command, which is implemented for all commands. The help text will usually contain a brief command description, the formal syntax, a list of supported parameters, and in some cases some additional usage notes.

Examples:

Show a list of MCS-DOS commands:

HELP

Show help on the COPY command:

HELP COPY

LABEL

Creates, changes, or deletes the volume label of a disk.

Syntax:

LABEL [drive:] [label]

Description:

“Volume label” is DOS terminology for a disk name. A Commodore 64 disk can have a name up to 16 characters in length. It will be displayed as a part of the directory listing shown by DIR, along with the disk ID (see DISKID). The VOL command will display both the label and the ID.

LABEL will prompt for a new name if the *label* parameter was not supplied. Pressing ENTER without specifying a name will delete the current name. The current drive will be assumed if none was specified with the command.

The cartridge storage does not have a volume label, and LABEL will therefore not work with it.

Examples:

Change or delete the volume label of the current disk, or a disk in the specified drive:

LABEL

LABEL A:

Explicitly set the volume label of a disk to “DATA”:

LABEL DATA

LABEL A: DATA

MEM

Displays the amount of used and free memory in your system.

Syntax:

MEM

Description:

MEM shows the total amount of installed RAM in your computer, and provides a breakdown of current memory usage. Below follows an annotated example of typical output:

65,536 bytes total memory	The total amount of RAM installed in your system.
29,967 bytes shell and workspace	The amount of RAM used by the permanently resident parts of MCS-DOS. This includes not only program code, but also space reserved for various buffers and caches.
2,048 bytes reserved for C stack	2 kilobytes are reserved for the dynamic allocation of variables used by the C program code.
8,192 bytes cartridge ROM window	8 kilobytes are reserved for “banking” in and out sections of program code and data stored on the cartridge ROM as needed.
15,361 bytes reserved for system	This denotes the amount of RAM used by the C64 and not claimed by MCS-DOS. It includes the KERNAL, the zero page, and the I/O stack.
9,968 bytes free	The amount of unused memory within the RAM areas allocated by MCS-DOS.

Note that MEM does not detect RAM Expansion Units (REU), as they typically occupy a cartridge slot, and can therefore not coexist with MCS-DOS on stock hardware. Even the “virtual” REUs available on equipment such as an Ultimate board would have their register range overlap with that of the EasyFlash that the MCS-DOS resides on, and are therefore not directly visible in the address space, requiring specialized methods.

MOVE

Copies the source file to the specified destination, then deletes the source.

Syntax:

MOVE source destination [/P]

Description:

The main use for MOVE is to relocate a file or group of files (as indicated by a wildcard) from one drive to another. It copies the file(s) to the destination, then deletes the original file(s). If the source and destination are on the same drive, the result is effectively the same using REN.

Examples:

Move a file from the current drive to drive B (9):

```
MOVE README.TXT B:
```

Move a group of files from drive B (9) to drive A (8):

```
MOVE 9:INVOICE* 8:
```

PAUSE

Suspends processing of a batch program and waits for a key to resume.

Syntax:

```
PAUSE [message]
```

Description:

PAUSE provides a way to pause execution of a batch file in case the user needs to perform some action such as swapping disks. Unless *message* is specified, it will echo:

```
Press any key to continue . . .
```

PRINT

Sends the contents of a file to a printer.

Syntax:

```
PRINT filename [4:|5:|LPT1|LPT2]
```

Description:

Default Commodore 64 printer devices are 4 and 5. MCS-DOS also accepts the DOS-style aliases LPT1 and LPT2. If a printer is connected to either one of these ports, the contents of the specified file are sent to it for printing.

PRINT works with the Ultimate 64/C64 Ultimate virtual printing feature, which outputs a PNG image or an ASCII or PETSCII text file. Refer to the Ultimate documentation for setup instructions.

Examples:

Send a file to a printer:

```
PRINT PAYSLIP.TXT 4:
PRINT CHANGELOG LPT2
```

REBOOT

Reboots the environment.

Syntax:

```
REBOOT
```

Description:

REBOOT restarts your MCS-DOS session. It skips the bootsplash and the system test, but does execute your CONFIG.SYS and AUTOEXEC.BAT if present. This can be useful when testing configuration changes.

REM

Records comments in a batch file.

Syntax:

```
REM [comment]
```

Description:

REM is used to annotate your batch scripts; it doesn't perform any action itself. You can also use REM without comment to add spacing for clarity. Nevertheless, as with all commands, the command is echoed during execution of a batch script, unless ECHO is OFF.

Example:

This batch program contains REM statements to add a functional description of the program and various explanations.

```
@ECHO OFF
REM SAVESTATS.BAT: Runs a check of the
REM disk in drive A and saves the
REM report.
REM
CHKDSK A: > DISKSTATS
TYPE DISKSTATS
```

REN

Changes the name of a file.

Syntax:

```
REN [drive:]filename1 [drive:]filename2
RENAME [drive:]filename1 [drive:]filename2
```

Description:

The REN command changes the name of a file, identified by *filename1*, to *filename2*. Wildcards are not supported. You can rename files on a different drive, although in that case both drive identifiers must match.

Examples:

```
REN EDITOR.C EDITOR-OLD.C
REN A:ADDRESSES A:ADDRESSES2
```

RENAME

Alias of REN.

RUN

Executes a program.

Syntax:

```
[drive:]filename [/A address]
```

Description:

RUN launches a batch file or a native C64 program from the MCS-DOS. While batch files run fully within the shell and guarantee resumption of control after completion, native programs may not do so. Many programs do not actually implement an exit, and for those that do, it is a requirement that they use the standard BASIC return at addresses \$0302-\$0303, and that they do not overwrite the \$C000-\$C1FF area, which contains the MCS-DOS shell re-entry hook. Otherwise, reset the machine (or, when using a physical EasyFlash, use the cartridge reset button) to start a new MCS-DOS session.

When the shell transfers control to an external program, the current shell state (including configuration, history, and internal caches) is saved to the cartridge, and restored if the MCS-DOS return hook is successfully reached. If restoration fails for some reason, default shell settings will be applied.

Batch files are recognized by existence of a .BAT extension as part of their filename.

The following switches are available:

/A Use for machine code programs without a BASIC stub (SYS <address>). The program will be loaded at the specified address and jumped to.

Examples:

Run a program:

```
RUN "MONTY ON THE RUN"  
RUN 8:CALC
```

Run a program at a specific address:

```
RUN TESTPROG /A 49152
```

SET

Displays, sets, or removes environment variables.

Syntax:

```
SET [variable=[string]]  
SET /ENV
```

Description:

MCS-DOS provides a 512 byte *environment* to store user-assigned variables in. The environment is normally used to configure shell settings from an AUTOEXEC.BAT startup file, which are processed and applied once execution finishes. To this end, MCS-DOS reserves a number of environment variable names – see chapter 7 for more information. Variables with custom names are not rejected, but do not currently serve any use.

Variable names have a maximum length of 8 characters, while their values can be up to 32 characters long. The settings are case-insensitive, and whitespace is ignored. A variable can be cleared by omitting the value.

Using SET without parameters shows a list of variables currently present in the environment.

The following switches are available:

/ENV Displays environment usage statistics. It shows the total environment size, the number of bytes used, and remaining environment space.

Examples:

Configure predefined shell settings (see chapter 7):

```
SET CHARSET=CGA
SET COLOR=3,6,6
SET DIRCMD=/ON
SET DRIVEIDS=DOS
SET PROMPT=$P$C$H$G
```

Clear an existing setting:

```
SET DIRCMD=
```

Show environment statistics:

```
SET /ENV
```

Show a list of current variables:

```
SET
```

SPLASH

Shows the MCS-DOS splash screen.

Syntax:

```
SPLASH
```

Description:

SPLASH reproduces the boot splash screen displayed when MCS-DOS is (re)started (except with REBOOT or a shell restore after returning from BASIC or when a program exits). It displays an MCS logo along with the MCS-DOS version and a copyright notice.

SYSINFO

Provides technical information on your computer.

Syntax:

```
SYSINFO
```

Description:

SYSINFO reproduces the system report that is displayed at MCS-DOS startup, after the bootsplash. It performs various tests to distinguish computer model, display mode, Ultimate board if installed, the

KERNAL revision, and any connected drives on device numbers 8 to 11. Other properties are inferred from the detected computer model.

The table below lists the properties that are detected by SYSINFO and their possible values.

Computer model	Commodore 64, Commodore SX-64, Commodore 128, Commodore 128DCR. C64C and C128D cannot be easily and reliably distinguished.
RAM	Inferred from computer model: 64K or 128K. REU is not detected due to register overlaps between EasyFlash and REU units. No attempt is made to detect “virtual” (Ultimate/emulated) units.
Display mode	PAL (50 Hz) or NTSC (60 Hz).
CPU	Inferred from computer model: MOS 6510/8500 Commodore 64 (8500 is 64C) MOS 6510 Commodore SX-64 MOS 6510 (FPGA) Ultimate 64 family MOS 8502 Commodore 128 family
Board	Shows Ultimate board version if one is detected: Ultimate 64, Ultimate 64 Elite, Ultimate 64 Elite-II, and Commodore 64 Ultimate. The latter may also appear as simply “Ultimate 64”. Note that the Ultimate Command Interface must be enabled for a successful detection. If detection still fails, re-enable and re-run SYSINFO.
KERNAL	Revisions 1 through 3, or SX-64. Select custom KERNALS are recognized; currently only JiffyDOS and DolphinDOS.
Disk drives	1541, 1541-II, 1570, 1571 and 1581 models. Their physical size (3.5” or 5.25”) along with their storage capacity, density and sidedness are displayed as well, but these are hardcoded per model, not physically detected.

TAPECOPY

Loads and transfers one or more files from tape to disk.

Syntax:

TAPECOPY [filename] [drive:]

Description:

TAPECOPY implements a tape (Datasette) loader that seeks and loads files, and presents the option to save them to the target drive. Specifying a file name will seek forward until that file is encountered. After agreeing or dismissing to save a file, the loader will continue to seek for new files unless the user deliberately exits. TAPECOPY does not support custom tape loaders and will terminate if non-standard headers are encountered; however, this is not a guarantee as custom loaders may not set a custom identifier. Any custom loader code is not executed.

To report progress, seek and find messages are displayed as in C64 BASIC:

```
SEARCHING  
FOUND <file>
```

Executable files (PRG) must be fully loaded into memory to allow for saving. The shell therefore suspends just as with entering BASIC or running native programs, with saved state restored afterwards. As parts of MCS-DOS must stay resident during the process, a file size limit of approximately 44 KB applies. Sequential data files (SEQ) are loaded into a buffer allocated in free RAM space and fragments written to the target disk, appending until transfer is complete; this process will not suspend the shell.

Examples:

Seek to the first file on tape and optionally save to drive A (8):

```
TAPECOPY A:
```

Seek to a specified file called "SAVEGAME" and optionally save to drive A (8):

```
TAPECOPY SAVEGAME A:
```

TYPE

Displays the contents of a file.

Syntax:

```
TYPE filename [/H[:n] | /T[:n] | /HEX]
```

Description:

By default, TYPE display the specified file as PETSCII text. For binary files, use the /HEX option to enable a hexadecimal viewing mode. TYPE will automatically paginate if the length of the file exceeds the current screen. You can press RUN/STOP to terminate.

The following switches are available:

/H[:n]	Shows the first <i>n</i> lines of a file (head).
/T[:n]	Shows the last <i>n</i> lines of a file (tail).
/HEX	Displays the raw bytes of a file, expressed as hexadecimal values.
/C	Specifies a number of characters or bytes instead of lines.

If *n* is not specified, 10 lines or bytes are assumed.

The hex viewer displays eight bytes per line. The first six digits represent the start address of the currently displayed line. It is followed by eight bytes, displayed as hexadecimal values, and then a text representation of these bytes with non-displayable characters rendered as dots (.).

A sample output might look as follows:

```
000000 01 08 0B 08 01 00 9E 32 .....2
000008 30 38 34 00 00 00 29 0F 084...).
(...)
```

Examples:

Show the contents of a text file called README:

```
TYPE README
```

Show the first 5 lines:

```
TYPE README /H:5
```

Show the last 5 lines:

```
TYPE README /T:5
```

Show the byte contents of a file called PROGRAM:

```
TYPE PROGRAM /HEX
```

Hex view works with head and tail options:

```
TYPE PROGRAM /HEX /H:5
```

```
TYPE PROGRAM /HEX /T:5
```

Show the first 40 characters/bytes of a text or binary file:

```
TYPE README /H:40 /C
```

```
TYPE PROGRAM /HEX /H:40 /C
```

VER

Displays the MCS-DOS version and copyright information.

Syntax:

```
VER
```

```
VERSION
```

Description:

The MCS-DOS 2.0 version string is hardcoded as follows:

```
MCS-DOS Version 2.0
```

```
Copyright (C) 2026 MCS Labs
```

VERSION

Alias of VER.

VOL

Displays the volume label (disk name) and disk ID, if they exist.

Syntax:

```
VOL [drive:]
```

Description:

If the drive is omitted, the volume information of the current drive is displayed. A volume label can be set with the LABEL command, the disk ID with DISKID. Both disk properties are also displayed by DIR and CHKDSK.

7.Environment variables

The MCS-DOS environment

MCS-DOS provides a 512 byte *environment* to store user-assigned variables in. These are formatted as key-value pairs, with a name of up to 8 characters long, and a value with a maximum length of 32 bytes. The environment is normally used to configure shell settings from an `AUTOEXEC.BAT` startup file, which are processed and applied once execution finishes.

Custom variable names are not rejected, but do not currently serve any purpose. In theory, external programs launched from MCS-DOS could access the environment by reading the address range `$56A9-$58A8` to extract variables for their own purposes, but this is not recommended as it is not guaranteed to remain stable; future versions may shift the range.

Several environment variables are available to configure shell layout and behavior. Set these in your `AUTOEXEC.BAT` to customize your experience, using the `SET` command. See chapter 6 for more information on `SET`. Note that these settings are only processed once `AUTOEXEC.BAT` finishes processing; modifying shell configuration variables with `SET` on the command prompt will have no effect.

The following variables can be used to configure the MCS-DOS shell:

CHARSET

Specifies a custom character set to be used by the shell.

Syntax:

```
SET CHARSET=name
```

Description:

The value of `name` corresponds with a matching `.CPI` file on the same drive from where the `AUTOEXEC.BAT` is executed. This is typically the MCS-DOS cartridge, but alternative locations can be set via the `BOOTDRV` directive in `CONFIG.SYS` (see chapter 4). The extension should be omitted.

If `CHARSET` is not set, the shell retains the default C64 ROM font. A standard MCS-DOS distribution ships with `CGA.CPI`, which reproduces the standard 8x8 IBM CGA font. Extra character sets can be downloaded from the source code repository: <https://github.com/mvanwijk83/mcs-dos/tree/main/extras>.

MCS-DOS `.CPI` files are not compatible with MS-DOS files with the same extension (Code Page Information); the `CPI` extension was adopted due to the vaguely similar purpose. Only alphanumeric and punctuation characters are replaced; PETSCII graphics characters are identical to the C64 ROM set.

Example:

Apply the character set defined by `CGA.CPI`.

```
SET CHARSET=CGA
```

COLOR

Configures the shell colors.

Syntax:

```
SET COLOR=c1,c2,c3
```

where:

c1 = foreground (text) color

c2 = background color

c3 = border color

Description:

The order foreground, background, border is fixed. All values must be specified, separated by commas. Standard Commodore 64 decimal color numbers must be used:

0	Black	8	Orange
1	White	9	Brown
2	Red	10	Pink
3	Cyan	11	Dark gray
4	Purple	12	Gray
5	Green	13	Light green
6	Blue	14	Light blue
7	Yellow	15	Light gray

The default setting is 15,0,0, which is light gray text on a black background with a black border area.

Example:

Set a uniform blue background with cyan text color:

```
SET COLOR=3,6,6
```

DIRCMD

Specifies default parameters to be used by the DIR command.

Syntax:

```
SET DIRCMD=[/B /L /Osortorder /W]
```

Description:

You can set the DIRCMD environment variable if you prefer DIR to always use a certain format or sort order. For example, you might want to force DIR to always sort files alphabetically, or to use lower case, or any combination of options that match your preference.

Example:

Always show directory contents with an alphabetical sort order, in lower case, but preserving the first written directory entry:

```
SET DIRCMD=/L /ONF
```

DRIVEIDS

Specify whether to display C64 drive numbers or DOS drive letters.

Syntax:

```
SET DRIVEIDS=C64 | DOS
```

Description:

Commands that display a drive identifier, such as DIR, CHKDSK, LABEL, or VOL, will follow the DRIVEIDS setting if present. The default format is C64 (drive number).

DOS drive letters start with A and map from C64 device number 8 onwards, so that device 8 is A, 9 is B, etc. The user-writeable cartridge storage area is always identified as drive 0 in both modes. It will not force the use of either format on the command prompt; both are always accepted, so e.g. DIR 8: and DIR A: will always work regardless of the display setting.

Examples:

Set the drive identifier display mode to C64:

```
SET DRIVEIDS=C64
```

Set the drive identifier display mode to DOS:

```
SET DRIVEIDS=DOS
```

PROMPT

Sets the format of the MCS-DOS command prompt.

Syntax:

```
SET PROMPT=format
```

Description:

The format string can contain literal text, as well as the following special codes:

\$B	(pipe symbol)	\$P	Drive identifier according to DRIVEIDS
\$C	: (colon)	\$Q	= (equals sign)
\$D	Drive letter	\$R	Line break (RETURN)
\$G	> (greater-than sign)	\$S	Space
\$H	\ (backslash)	\$V	MCS-DOS version number
\$N	Drive number	\$	Dollar sign

The default setting if PROMPT is not set is `$P$C$G`, which yields `A:>` or `8:>`, depending on DRIVEIDS (`0:>` in all cases for the cartridge storage). The format codes are case-insensitive.

Examples:

Show a DOS drive letter followed by a colon and a backslash (e.g. `A:\>`):

```
SET PROMPT=$D$C$G
```

Mimic a BASIC-style “ready” prompt, with the drive identifier (following the configured format) and a colon on a new line:

```
SET PROMPT=READY.$R$P$C
```

8. Command output redirection

The screen output of certain commands can be redirected to a file; that is to say, their output is written to a new or existing file. Supported are CHKDSK, DIR, ECHO, FIND, MEM and TYPE.

To redirect output to a new file, use the > operator. If the file already exists, it will be overwritten without asking confirmation. Example:

```
DIR /B > FILES.TXT
```

To append to an existing file, use >>. Example:

```
ECHO Call John about the upcoming meeting >> NOTES
```

As with file operations in general, drive prefixes can be added, e.g.:

```
MEM > 9:"MY MEMORY.TXT"  
CHKDSK >> A:DISKSTATS.TXT
```

Pagination prompts that would appear when running the command normally from the command prompt do not appear in the redirected text.

Redirection to printers is currently not supported. A workaround is to redirect to a file, and then use the PRINT command to send its contents to a printer, e.g.:

```
DIR /L /ON > TEMP  
PRINT TEMP 4:  
DEL TEMP
```

9. Batch scripting

Batch files can be useful to automate repetitive tasks that you might find yourself doing in MCS-DOS. Repeating sequences of MCS-DOS commands can be put in a batch file, which can then be run from the command prompt.

Creating and running batch files

To create a batch file, you can use the built-in editor invoked by the `EDIT` command, or use an external text editor if you prefer, or require the ability to create a larger file (`EDIT` is limited to 24 lines). Like native programs, batch files are executed using the `RUN` command. Batch files must have a `.BAT` extension as part of their file name to be recognized by the MCS-DOS command interpreter. Since C64 file names have a maximum length of 16 characters including the artificial extension, this leaves 12 characters to give a proper name to your batch files.

Batch processing

Batch files are a sequence of MCS-DOS commands, and those commands behave the same as if they were being individually ran on the command prompt. For example, changing the active drive in a batch file will persist that state until another drive switch is effected – and remains even after the batch file has finished processing and the prompt is restored.

The default behavior is that all commands in a batch file are displayed on screen while the batch file is running. To suppress it, include an `ECHO OFF` command. To prevent the `ECHO OFF` command from being echoed itself, prefix it with an `@`, i.e. `@ECHO OFF`.

Any screen output and error messages produced by batch commands are displayed on screen as they also would on the command prompt. `RUN/STOP` to terminate if the currently running command supports it.

Some batch file limitations are:

- Batch files cannot call other batch files.
- There are no program-like constructs such as variables, conditionals, labels, or parameters (arguments).

Example

The following batch script automates a disk duplication procedure. It prompts the user to put a new disk in drive B (9), and asks the user to press a key to continue. The disk is subsequently formatted. The user is then asked to insert a disk in drive A (8). After another key press, the contents of the disk in drive A are copied to the disk in drive B. Finally, a disk status report is saved to the target disk and displayed on screen.

```
@ECHO OFF
REM BACKUP.BAT - formats a new disk in
REM drive B and copies the contents of
REM the disk in drive A.
REM -----
ECHO Put the destination disk in drive B.
PAUSE
FORMAT B:
```

```
ECHO.  
ECHO Put the source disk in drive A.  
PAUSE  
DISKCOPY A: B:  
ECHO.  
CHKDSK B: > B:DISKSTATUS  
TYPE B:DISKSTATUS  
ECHO Done.
```

AUTOEXEC.BAT

The main startup configuration file, `AUTOEXEC.BAT`, is a regular batch file. Use it to run any MCS-DOS commands you wish at startup and to configure shell settings. An example `AUTOEXEC.BAT`, named `AUTOEXEC.SAMPLE`, is included on the cartridge.

See “Boot configuration” in chapter 4 for more information, and chapter 7 (Environment variables) for settings you can apply. Execution can be skipped at the bootsplash screen by pressing `RESTORE`.

10. Changelog

Version 1.0 Preview

(13-Sep-2026)

Preliminary limited public release.

Version 1.0

(15-Sep-2026)

- Fixed a bug where DEL did not report failed deletion when a file is locked.
- Removed /S switches (omit decimal separators) from MEM and CHKDSK as they were of limited utility.
- Small memory usage reduction by various code optimizations.
- General code cleanup.
- Finalized inline and offline documentation.
- Finalized release package.
- Source code release.

Version 1.01

(19-Sep-2026)

- Added /P switch to COPY (overwrite without user confirmation).
- ECHO text ending in ; will omit the line terminator (use ;; to escape).
- Expanded memory usage report produced by MEM.
- Press RESTORE on boot screen for "safe mode" (skips executing AUTOEXEC.BAT).

Version 2.0

(03-Oct-2026)

- MCS-DOS is now distributed as an EasyFlash cartridge image to support new feature development, reduce memory usage, and improve performance in some areas. The cartridge contains a 62.5 KB user-writable area that can be used as any other storage device.
- Added support for CONFIG.SYS to configure boot behaviour.
- The command help library is no longer represented as a file (COMMANDS.HLP) but stored as internal cartridge data.
- Improved native program support: programs with a clean exit to BASIC and that preserve \$C000-\$C1FF will return to the shell.
- The BASIC command replaces EXIT. It enters the C64 BASIC environment and implements a wedge (SHELL) to return to MCS-DOS.
- Added DISKINIT command to refresh drive cache and status, equivalent to the CBM-DOS INITIALIZE command.
- Added TAPECOPY command to transfer files from tape to disk.
- Added SYSINFO command that displays basic system information.
- Added head, tail and hex view options to TYPE (/H, /T, /HEX).

- Added /P switch to MOVE to suppress file overwrite prompt.
- Added /C switch to CHKDSK to perform a cartridge filesystem compaction on demand. Additionally, the standard CHKDSK report now also identifies the drive model and lists the native C64 device number and corresponding DOS letter alias.
- Changed the DOS-style "R" file attribute letter for the file lock bit to "L", matching actual C64 behavior.
- DEleting files with a wildcard will now prompt for individual confirmation for each matching file, unless /P is specified.
- Added file redirection support for FIND, and removed it from HELP.
- Revised boot sequence with a system information report and a startup message.
- REU test in MEM removed due to register overlap between EasyFlash and the REU.
- Revised some system messages.

11. About the author

I grew up with both C64s and old PCs. This project is thus a natural crossover between the computer platforms that were both a big part of my youth. My early tinkering with C64 and PC BASICs was instrumental in eventually becoming a professional software developer.

With my last C64 dying on my somewhere during the mid 90s, and having moved on to PCs, I got into C64 emulation during the noughties. During that same decade, I became active in the demoscene (albeit as a PC musician and under a different handle), where Commodore is never far away. I attended several editions of X, among many other events across Europe.

The recent resurrection of Commodore excited me, and I bought a C64 Ultimate. Owning physical hardware again inspired me to once more become creative on the C64, hence this release. And who knows what else the future may bring.

"MCS" is an alias I used in my early days for my hobby programming. It only seemed suitable to bring it back. It also makes for a nice pun to refer to this software's relationship to MS-DOS.

Links

MCS Labs on GitHub

<https://github.com/mvanwijk83>

MCS Labs on itch.io

<https://mcs-labs.itch.io/>